

No. 6

**Letter by the Chairman of the SPD, Brandt, to the General Secretary
of the CC of the CPSU, Brezhnev**

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English translation: Dwight E. Langston

Dear Mr. General Secretary,

First of all I would like to express my delight at the fact that you consider it appropriate to renew our exchange of opinions. I discern in your words² the concern that developments could head in the wrong direction and the desire to prevent that. I share both your concern and your desire.

My reply is expressed with the forthright and friendly openness without which we could not have developed that relationship between our countries which is well worth maintaining and building on.

Of course, being at the head of a world power, it is clear to you what kind of advantage you have in terms of information at your disposal compared to me, who no longer bears any immediate governmental responsibility. But perhaps, even from my present position, unchanged in my devotion to the continuation of our work, and not involved in significant issues of international developments, I can still contribute something to seeing that things do not head in the wrong direction. I do that without knowing many technical details of weapons development which you and others have at your disposal, knowledge which is important but which does not have to be decisive and determining, especially since statesmen have no desire to become top experts.

The situation seems to be confusing: The Americans tell us that, since SALT II³ and in view of the Soviet Union's growing superiority in the area of medium-range missiles, they need a counterbalance, and our own place in the alliance is such that we can hardly distance ourselves from that position. Your country tells us that it has no superiority and also does not wish to achieve it. I believe, however, that your country has a conventional superiority. I believe that your country is amassing a superiority in the area of medium-range missiles, where the West lags behind, a position it does not care to be in.⁴

I find nothing to contradict the argument that the Soviet Union is changing in its favour the balance obtained so far through construction of the SS 20 and the bomber we know by the name "Backfire."⁵ I am a dedicated adherent to the thesis that there is only joint security, that a partnership of security must be developed⁶ and that the creation of imbalances prevents that.

I find little to contradict the argument that the West would not only keep pace with its new plans, but could also create additional security for itself if those plans were to be carried out in their entirety – which the Soviet Union would not accept.

Therefore, we now face the danger of a new turn of the armament screw, one which cannot create more security but rather more insecurity. Most of all, it can lead to a situation where we forget – by focusing our thinking solely on our military security above and against that of others – that we need to cultivate cooperation with each other. Through that situation we will not create more trust, but rather mistrust. We must not allow that to be our future. Whoever wishes to prevent such a situation must insist that both sides sit down at the table so that everything they have can be put on the table.

I see that you want that. The West also wants that. In saying so, I do not fail at all to recognise that elements may exist in the West who want to exploit this opportunity to achieve a renewed superiority over the Soviet Union, or who do not seriously wish to achieve any results or who

would profit from a worsening of relations between Bonn and Moscow. I cannot conjure these elements away with a magic wand; we must simply not capitulate to them. I hold to the opinion that nothing can take precedence over negotiations.

In Berlin, you made interesting and important proposals in good faith which you later supplemented and made more precise.⁷ By doing that, you set more into motion than many Soviet statements appear to recognise. The planned Western resolutions will not remain uninfluenced by that fact. You know my position, and that of my party, on this complex.⁸ I add the following here: unilateral measures can also be revoked unilaterally; offers of negotiations have to be made use of. I am glad that the Federal Chancellor has made a unilateral offer as well. 1000 nuclear warheads can certainly be comparable to 1000 tanks and 20 000 men.⁹ Of course, both sides can say that the most recent material is not at issue here. But what is that supposed to mean? It is still apparent that each side has different advantages which can be reduced without endangering its own security. And from that reality we can still draw the following conclusion: Nothing must take precedence over negotiations and nothing can replace agreements anchored in international law.

I do not wish to deal with the development which leads to this situation, because that does not help anything. I can no more preclude mistakes on our side than I can mistakes on your side. Everything needs to be focused on a sober examination of the situation and on steering developments in the right direction. What is sober? NATO will make such a determination on 12 December; but as a result, new weapons will definitely not be stationed for another three or four years.¹⁰ I was interested to read that you emphasised the issue of stationing in your address in Berlin.¹¹ That is definitely the important issue. Therefore, it is essential to make good use of this time.

In this matter as well, I am taking into account the fact that some consider only one result to be possible, one which, similar to SALT,¹² also agrees on a balance for the so-called Euro-strategic weapons region,

an agreement which would also mean something for the West in addition to the present situation. I'll say openly that I would not be enthusiastic about such a result but, in any event, it would be a joint result. We could live with that. Better and more worthwhile is an outcome which results in no additional medium-range missiles on the Western side.¹³ That requires something reciprocal from your side. Not only my Soviet respondents, but also others, doubt whether it is realistic to produce such weapons in the first place but then not station them. But that is precisely what we must attempt to do, specifically for the sake of global balance, which you refer to and whose uninterrupted preservation I consider so important. Whether or not we succeed in coming to a negotiated settlement and to a balance of security with no new missiles on the Western side, will depend to a great extent on your side.

We cannot object much to our American allies' positions as long as they can point to continuing Soviet production.¹⁴ I feel secure with the relative balance achieved so far and feel no need for missiles which could reach Soviet territory from here. But, to prevent the stationing of such missiles, I need the reassurance that the existing balance is not further unilaterally changed on the Soviet side.

At no time has the SPD left any doubt as to its position and its will. The Executive Committee has prepared resolutions on foreign policy and security policy which are unambiguous and will certainly be adopted at our upcoming party convention.¹⁵ The SPD affirms the policy of the treaties, the crucial significance of our relationship with the Soviet Union, the development of our long-term cooperation, and the statement agreed on during your visit that no one aspires to military dominance and that approximate equality and parity are sufficient to assure adequate defence.¹⁶ In questions of security policy, the party convention will probably affirm the Hamburg Resolution on neutron weapons,¹⁷ and for the rest, a proposal has been made that there must be no automatisms regarding the issue of medium-range missiles. The course of negotiations and the anticipated results must make it possible at any time to examine

and to revise resolutions. For these reasons, the Federal Government should agree to such a resolution only under the condition that the introduction of such weapons must be renounced if arms control negotiations are to achieve satisfactory results.¹⁸ In our opinion, the goal of negotiations is to make the introduction of additional medium-range weapons in Europe superfluous. In other words: the SPD wants to continue, even and especially in this election year, its policy of peaceful cooperation with the nations of Eastern Europe, bearing in mind, of course, the Federal Republic of Germany's alliance obligations and the necessity to support the Federal Government in this; but for that purpose, it needs partners.

You referred to the visit by my friends from the Socialist International.¹⁹ It aroused particular attention that you took the time to receive the delegation. We received a report in Lisbon²⁰ and resolved that in the fall of next year [1980] the convention²¹ will be principally concerned with matters of disarmament and arms control. Prior to that, the party leaders will have already addressed the matter in Vienna.²² The conviction is growing that mounting expenditures for armaments, in the East as in the West, are economic nonsense and, in view of the problems which humanity faces, hardly responsible. One needs to draw the necessary conclusions from that conviction.

Again we reach the following conclusion: the requisite negotiations must take place. I do not consider your misgivings justified that they now have to be conducted from a "position of strength" because of the December Resolution by NATO.²³ In practical terms, the NATO Resolution simply means that not only will the Soviet Union continue to produce, but also the United States. If you had been in a position to announce a unilateral stop to production, then, in my opinion, the planned December Resolution by NATO would no longer have come to fruition. But compared with other instances, I see in your position, as in that of the West as well, a wish to do nothing which might disturb the ratification of SALT II.²⁴ I welcome the fact that there exists, within the

four years lying between the decision to produce and the possibility of stationing,²⁵ a certain period of pressure toward negotiations. It affects both sides and should be put to positive use, the more so since progress in negotiations always brings with it the possibility of jointly making more time for oneself.

I consider it very important to make use of this time. By that I mean: next year should not be lost because of the elections in the USA and in my country.²⁶ It means, for all practical purposes, that no one should allow the first few months of next year elapse without beginning preparations for negotiations in which we Germans have the utmost interest, even if we have no atomic weapons at our disposal and also do not wish to have any.

I have been completely open in informing you about how I see the situation. You will gather from that how much I share your aspirations to preserve Europe from falling back into senseless tensions. I believe that to be possible. If I did not consider it possible to pursue the course I have described to you with positive chances for success, I would surely not wish to deceive you.

With complete sincerity.

Yours truly,

<Willy Brandt>²⁷

¹ The template copy here is a copy of Brandt's letter.

² Letter from Leonid Brezhnev to Willy Brandt, November 1979, in: AdsD, WBA, A 9,7.

³ Cf. No. 7, Note 4.

⁴ Indeed there was no weapons system on western side comparable to the Soviet medium-range ballistic missile SS-20 as well as the modern Soviet Swing-Wing Bomber, in NATO jargon called "Backfire". Cf. *Hacke* 1997, p. 171 ff.

⁵ Ibid.

⁶ The notion of security partnership or rather Egon Bahr's concept of "common security" formed in the eighties the conceptual core of social-democratic security policy from an opposition platform. Cf. *Berliner Ausgabe*, vol. 10.

⁷ Meant here is Brezhnev's speech from 6 October 1979 in East-Berlin where he not only stated that a deployment of new American medium-range ballistic missiles in Western Europe would destroy the, in his opinion, existing balance of established power (regardless of SS-20 armament) but threatened with a "counterstrike" against the Federal Republic. Moreover he announced the unilateral and unconditional withdrawal of up to 20,000 Soviet soldiers and 1,000 tanks from the GDR. Cf. EA 33 (1978) 21, D 556-560, and *Schöllgen* 1996, p. 364.

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- ⁸ Brandt and large sections of the SPD hoped that the negotiation options of NATO's double-track decision could overlay the options of deployment to that effect that a resounding negotiation success could make the deployment of new missiles completely superfluous. It has become a habit to call this ideal case "zero option".
- ⁹ The withdrawal of 1,000 American nuclear warheads from Europe was already part of NATO's double-track decision of 12 December 1979. Cf. EA 35 (1980) 2, D 36.
- ¹⁰ On 12 December 1979 in a special meeting in Brussels the ministers of foreign affairs and defence from those NATO member states which formed the integrated defence structure agreed on the so called NATO's double-track decision. In it they decided to modernize NATO's system of medium-range ballistic missiles in Europe by American ground-based systems. "This included 108 launch units for Pershing II [...] and 464 ground-based cruise missiles" Parallel and in conjunction to the deployment option, the second part of the decision contained the offer to the Soviet leadership to start the negotiations concerning the "American and Soviet LRTNF" "as soon as possible", namely "bilateral within the scope of SALT III". Cf. EA 35 (1980) 2, D 35-37. For technical reasons the earliest possible time for the deployment of American medium-range ballistic missiles of type Pershing II and of cruise missiles was autumn of 1983.
- ¹¹ Note 7.
- ¹² Cf. No. 7, Note 4.
- ¹³ Cf. Note 8.
- ¹⁴ Meant here is the Soviet SS-20 production.
- ¹⁵ Meant here is the SPD party congress from 3 to 7 December 1979 in Berlin.
- ¹⁶ Cf. No. 46, Note 4.
- ¹⁷ Cf. No 42, Note 4.
- ¹⁸ Brandt refers to the National Security Council's (Bundessicherheitsrat) decision from January of 1978 regarding the neutron weapons. This decision now served as a model for the position toward a possible deployment of American medium-range ballistic missiles in the Federal Republic of Germany. According to it, as Federal Chancellor Schmidt said on 13 April 1978, the deployment of nuclear weapons in Germany was permitted if the western side does not renounce it within two years after the American decision to produce the missiles on grounds of a positive result of negotiations on arms limitation. Cf. EA 33 (1978) 9, D 293.
- ¹⁹ Meant here is a meeting between Brezhnev and members of the Socialist International's study group on arms limitation on 1 October 1979 in Moscow. In his speech Brezhnev explained, among others, that the Soviet Union threatens nobody and only the West is responsible for the continuation of arms race. Cf. EA 34 (1979) 21, I. 197.
- ²⁰ Meant here is the meeting of the Bureau of the Socialist International on 30/31 October 1979 in Lisbon.
- ²¹ Brandt refers to the 15th Congress of the Socialist International in mid-November 1980 in Madrid.
- ²² Meant here is the Socialist International's Party Leaders Conference on 5/6 February 1980 in Vienna.
- ²³ Cf. note 10.
- ²⁴ On 18 June 1979 US President Carter and Soviet Secretary General Brezhnev signed the second Agreement on Strategic Arms Limitation (SALT II) in Vienna. The treaty reduced the number of intercontinental ballistic missiles for both sides. Cf. the treaty with related documents, in: EA 34 (1979) 15, D 368-400, and No. 7, note 4.
- ²⁵ Cf. note 10.
- ²⁶ Meant here are the Bundestag election on 5 October 1980 and the American presidential election on 4 November 1980.
- ²⁷ Handwritten signature.